Pradeep Penugonda

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12 October 2026

The Selection Panel
Caulfield Grammar School, Wheelers Hill Campus

Application | Chemistry/Science Teacher, Wheelers Hill (permanent, full-time)

Dear Selection Panel,

I am applying for the permanent full-time Chemistry and Science position at Wheelers Hill. I registered an expression of interest with the School earlier this year, and this is my application for this specific vacancy. I teach Years 7 to 9 Science at St Francis Xavier College across seven classes and have done since 2023.

On Chemistry, I want to be precise. I teach the chemical sciences strand at Years 7 to 9, and my most substantial piece of teaching this year was a chemistry unit: Separation Techniques with a Year 7 class. I have not taught VCE Chemistry. What sits behind my Chemistry is laboratory work rather than senior classroom experience. My research ran on protein purification, SDS-PAGE, western blotting, mass spectrometry and restriction digestion, and at Eurofins I did instrument calibration, media preparation and quality control testing under Good Laboratory Practices. I would bring real analytical depth to senior Chemistry, and I would expect to work hard at its pedagogy in my first year. Biology is my strongest discipline, which may be useful in a small team.

On formative practice and feedback. In that Separation Techniques unit, every lesson followed the same structure: a visible learning intention, chunked explicit instruction, a structured practical, then a quick assessment with feedback given in the same lesson. I set the success criteria before teaching began and measured against three independent instruments rather than one test. The class median rose from a 51% baseline to 70%, and students scoring 80% or above went from none to eleven of 28. It was not uniform. One student went backwards on the written task, which I traced to vocabulary rather than the chemistry, and that shaped the next unit.

On technology and differentiation. I build my own animations and visual sequences, which is how I keep theory efficient and protect time for practical work. I write Standard and Personalised Learning Plan versions of assessments so that students on plans work on the same science as their peers. I introduced dissection practicals at Year 7 for the first time at my campus and shared a second dissection across both of our campuses with full instructions for colleagues.

On wellbeing. I run a voluntary lunchtime science support service, approved by our Head of Education and open to any student in the College rather than only those I teach. Students from other teachers' classes seek me out, and some book a time in advance.

Your position description lists postgraduate qualifications as desirable. I hold a Master of Teaching (Secondary Education), a Master of Science in Biotechnology and Bioinformatics from La Trobe completed with High Distinction, and a Master of Science in Microbiology, along with three peer-reviewed publications. I have not worked in the MYP, but its inquiry model is close to how I already teach and I would be glad to learn it properly.

My VIT registration is provisional and my full registration evidence is with VIT now. Wheelers Hill is an easy drive from Carnegie. My resume is attached.

Yours sincerely,

Pradeep Penugonda
Secondary Science Teacher | Permanent Resident | Working with Children Check current